



Generational shift: A final that felt like a baton pass — from Humpy's legacy to Divya's rise. ANNASHTOURMAN/FIDE

in the tournament's decisive phase, it was Divya's energy that proved more effective.

It was a fairytale finish for the girl from Nagpur, who prevailed 2.5-1.5 after the two classical-format games ended in draws. In the tiebreaks, the second rapid game proved decisive when Humpy faltered more than once in a tense endgame. She could not capitalise on Divya's late oversight and eventually blundered, handing her younger opponent a memorable title win.

For Divya, the World Cup was worth much more than the top prize of \$50,000 (approximately ₹43.35 lakh). The victory brought with it the Grandmaster title — remarkable

considering she arrived at the event without a single GM norm to her name.

Divya, who became only the fourth Indian woman to earn the Grandmaster title, took the country's tally to 88. By topping the field, she led a trio of qualifiers for the Candidates Tournament, which decides who will challenge the reigning World Champion from China.

After India secured two of the three Candidates spots, Tan Zhongyi

beat Chinese teammate and favourite Lei Tingjie 1.5-0.5 by winning the second classical game.

For the first time, India outplayed so many strong Chinese challengers in a marquee individual event. Divya ousted the second and third seeds — Zhu Jiner and Tan Zhongyi — while Humpy eliminated top seed Lei Tingjie after clawing back from a 0-1 deficit to win 5-3 in a high-stakes semifinal.

Of the nine Indians who competed, four reached the

« Humpy's experience exceeded Divya's age, but in the crunch, it was Divya's energy that proved more effective »